its victory provided momentum whereby it could continue to squeeze the rump American alliance network and steadily put pressure on the nonaligned bloc. Publicly, Chinese officials repeatedly maintained that Beijing considered the diplomatic solution as merely "temporary," and that China would not rule out further action to follow up on its gains, but it failed to put into motion any plans to take advantage of its success. Moreover, as discussed, Beijing soon discovered that its unwilling allies required the investment of Chinese political, economic, and military capital, which restricted Beijing's freedom of action postbellum.

The United States limited its strategic goals to protecting Japan and ensuring that it could operate in part of East Asia's marginal seas (namely, the eastern portion of the East China Sea) as well as beyond the outer crescent of Japan. This allowed for the possibility of power projection into the inner seas and littorals in a future crisis, but turned the US largely into an offshore balancer, with its forces concentrated in Hawaii and on Guam. That made its remaining alliances, with Japan and Australia, inherently weaker than before the war.

The end result was a trifurcation of the Indo-Pacific into three geopolitical blocs, two of which—the Chinese and American—were mutually antagonistic, while the third, nonaligned block maneuvered for advantage between the other two. A cold peace settled on East Asia, reducing, though not eliminating, intraregional trade, while multilateral diplomatic mechanisms such as those sponsored by ASEAN became arenas for rhetorical combat between the blocs. A sharp drop in Sino-US trade rocked both countries, with the United States entering a recession that lasted three years, while reports of widespread demonstrations in China hinted at pervasive domestic unrest. Trade slowly stabilized between the two, but some of the nonaligned countries, particularly India, Vietnam, and Malaysia, retooled their economies to supplant China in the global supply chain, leading to a boost in their exports to America and Europe.

As the cold peace settled on the region, the Chinese and American blocs settled down into a prolonged contest for influence in Asia. Beijing continued its military buildup, though at a slower pace than during the